

Maddening shortages in Argentina can try the patience of a family therapist. In the Argentine beach town of Pinamar, I once went to buy beer, a couple of steaks, bread, and bus tickets back to Buenos Aires. The beverage store was out of beer. The owner explained that he had no empty bottles; the beer company was short on bottles and wouldn't deliver unless the store had empties to exchange. The butcher had no beef—his supplier had failed to show up that day. The bakery had a few cookies but no bread. And the bus station ticket office had run out of ticket blanks. The woman behind the counter told me she had run out of tickets several days before; she wondered why Buenos Aires was so slow in delivering new stock.

I returned home empty-handed and frustrated. But Vicki served wine instead of beer, chicken instead of steaks, and pasta instead of bread. We showed up at the bus station the following day, got on board, and paid the driver.

MEXICO

Most tourists to Mexico do a one-week package deal to Cancún for \$729 plus tax, or about \$1,500 for two people. Their Mexico sparkles with glass and glitter. Their Mexico brings in more hard currency than any Mexican export except oil. Their Mexico is carefully controlled by the National Tourist Board. Their Mexico pegs its prices to the U.S. dollar, makes sure everyone speaks at least some English, and has a ready excuse when the air-conditioning breaks down.

Their Mexico is as different from the Mexico Vicki and I know as Kansas City is from New York. With \$1,500 Vicki and I buy our plane tickets and live in Mexico for two months rather than one week. We live in peso-based rather than dollar-based Mexico. And we feel we're closer to the Mexican people, their culture, and their traditions.

In 1982 foreign bankers began to rein in their lending to